were operating), meant the B-26s arrived well after the A-4s had departed back to the *Essex*.

The émigrés stood no chance of achieving their military objective, though they fought hard: government forces suffered an estimated 3,650 casualties including 1,250 deaths; 1,179 members of Brigade 2506 were captured; 114 were killed; the rest escaped or were evacuated.[54] The prisoners remained in Cuban jails until their release was brokered in December 1962, when they were exchanged for supplies of medicines and food.

The CIA underestimated the fighting ability of Castro's troops (including their pilots) as well as their ability to move through difficult terrain. They also underestimated Fidel Castro's qualities as a leader. Newsreels showed him directing his troops in battle. The more fundamental failure of the CIA and the Kennedy administration concerned the prospects for revolt. Fourteen hundred men stood little chance of prevailing over an army of 32,000 supported by a militia of over 200,000. The prerequisite for the success of Operation Zapata was that the landing would have a profound psychological effect on the Cuban population and spark a general uprising.

The CIA plan was dependent on this spontaneous insurrection. Yet Bissell chose to exclude analysts in the Directorate of Intelligence and used only officials in his Directorate of Operations.[55] Within the agency there was no sound analytical foundation for the critical assumption on which the operation was based. Various anti-Castro groups within Cuba, including those fighting in the Escambray mountains, were expected to join the revolt. Yet the CIA did not tell them the timing of the invasion (for security reasons) or attempt to coordinate their actions in support of an uprising. Instead, Castro had thousands of opponents arrested, further undermining the CIA plan. Perhaps, most astonishingly, while Bissell told the President that the brigade could escape to the Escambray mountains, he did not impart this news to the commanders of the brigade (who would presumably have taken the opportunity of explaining what a crocodile-infested mangrove swamp looked like).

The overthrow of Fidel Castro was, nevertheless, feasible if Kennedy was prepared to commit US forces in sufficient strength. The US military,